DETROIT, UNITED STATES

Detroit Institute of Arts: Masterpieces

Twenty works that make the relationship between a figure and its surroundings impossible to ignore.



A worker in Rivera's factory has a task and a place within a vast system. The sleeper in Fuseli's *The Nightmare* occupies an equally definite space, but the beings around her make its rules uncertain. Between these extremes, a bar, a study and a bookshop show people giving shape to their everyday surroundings.

This selection from the Detroit Institute of Arts follows those different kinds of enclosure. A room can protect concentration, organise labour or trap a body. It can also be opened up by colour until its walls cease to feel solid. The works do not offer a common answer; they provide useful ways of asking how much space a person has, and who or what controls it.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/detroit-institute-arts

The selection · 20

1. The Nightmare
   Henry Fuseli · 1781
2. Detroit Industry: North Wall
   Diego Rivera · 1932–1933
3. Nocturne in Black and Gold: The Falling Rocket
   James Abbott McNeill Whistler · 1875
4. Martha and Mary Magdalene
   Caravaggio · 1598
5. The Window
   Henri Matisse · 1916
6. Cotopaxi
   Frederic Edwin Church · 1862
7. Saint Jerome in His Study
   Jan van Eyck · c. 1435
8. Saint Jerome in the Desert
   Workshop of Rogier van der Weyden · 1450–1465
9. McSorley's Bar
   John Sloan · 1912
10. Love Flight of a Pink Candy Heart
    Florine Stettheimer · 1930
11. Bookshop: Hebrew Books, Holy Day Books
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12. Study for Crouching Nude
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13. View of the Outskirts of Paris
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15. The Holy Family
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16. The Blind Leading the Blind
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17. The Elbe near Dresden
    Oskar Kokoschka · 1921
18. The Wolf River, Kansas
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19. Girl with a Mandolin
    Giovanni Battista Tiepolo · 1758-1760
20. Job
    Jacob Jordaens · c. 1620

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The Nightmare

Henry Fuseli

1781 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Henry Fuseli. The Nightmare. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The sleeper's body lies across the bed while a creature sits squarely on her torso. Behind them, a horse's head enters through the dark curtains. Fuseli gives these intruders the same physical presence as the furniture. A nightmare is represented as an occupation of the room: the woman cannot respond, while the impossible beings appear entirely at home.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Detroit Industry: North Wall

Diego Rivera

1932–1933 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Diego Rivera. Detroit Industry, North Wall. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Repeated bodies and pipes carry activity across Rivera's factory scene. Each worker has a local task, yet the mural's scale insists on the larger system joining those tasks together. Made in 1932–1933, the North Wall belongs to a surrounding fresco cycle. A reproduction can clarify individual actions, but it cannot reproduce the experience of industrial production occupying an entire architectural enclosure.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Nocturne in Black and Gold: The Falling Rocket

James Abbott McNeill Whistler

1875 · Detroit Institute of Arts



James Abbott McNeill Whistler. Nocturne in Black and Gold – the Falling Rocket. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Gold marks descend through darkness without describing every stage of the firework's path. Water, figures and distance remain only partially resolved. Whistler gives enough information to recognise a spectacle, then leaves colour and scattered light to do the rest. The lack of detail is functional: a fully mapped setting would compete with the brief visibility of the falling sparks.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Martha and Mary Magdalene

Caravaggio

1598 · Oil on canvas · Detroit Institute of Arts



Martha and Mary Magdalene. WikiArt; Caravaggio. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The mirror makes appearance an object within the conversation. One woman speaks; the other's hand turns attention towards her own body. Caravaggio brings the religious subject into this close exchange, withholding a larger public setting. The changing relation between the women matters more than spectacle: a gesture can register a response that an elaborately described room would not explain.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

The Window

Henri Matisse

1916 · Oil on canvas · Detroit Institute of Arts



Henri Matisse. The Window. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-matisse/the-window-1916 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Matisse places the green outside beside the blue interior with a firmness that can make distance seem almost optional. Table, chair and flowers remain recognisable, but their outlines also divide the canvas into neighbouring areas. The window therefore works in two ways: as an opening in a room and as a boundary between colours on a flat surface.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Cotopaxi

Frederic Edwin Church

1862 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Frederic Edwin Church. Cotopaxi (Ecuador). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Smoke spreads beyond the volcano until the eruption changes the light of the whole view. Church combines a carefully articulated foreground with a horizon that cannot remain stable. The landscape's small details provide a scale against which the event can be measured. The important action is not confined to the mountain; it is carried through the reddish air.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Saint Jerome in His Study

Jan van Eyck

c. 1435 · Oil on linen paper on oak panel · Detroit Institute of Arts



Jan van Eyck. St. Jerome in his Study. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jan-van-eyck/st-jerome-in-his-study-1432 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Books and instruments make Jerome's study a place of disciplined attention. The lion at his feet brings the saint's legend into that intellectual setting. This is a very small panel, about twenty centimetres high, whose objects reward close inspection. Its attribution has varied historically; the DIA currently lists Jan van Eyck and a date of about 1435.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Saint Jerome in the Desert

Workshop of Rogier van der Weyden

1450–1465 · Oil on oak panel · Detroit Institute of Arts



Saint Jerome and the Lion. WikiArt; Rogier van der Weyden. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Here Jerome attends to the lion's paw rather than to the books surrounding him in the previous work. Angular rocks enclose the pair, giving an outdoor episode the concentration of a small room. The museum attributes the panel to Rogier van der Weyden's workshop, a distinction worth preserving: its connection to a master's practice does not establish that he painted it himself.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

McSorley's Bar

John Sloan

1912 · Detroit Institute of Arts



John Sloan. McSorley's Bar. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Leaning, standing and waiting give Sloan's bar its social arrangement. The white-clad worker draws attention within the dark room, but no incident makes everyone else a supporting character. Pictures and fixtures crowd the walls as the men occupy the counter. This is a space understood through repeated use, where the distribution of bodies matters more than an identifiable story.

Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

Love Flight of a Pink Candy Heart

Florine Stettheimer

1930 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Florine Stettheimer. Love Flight of a Pink Candy Heart. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Stettheimer does not ask every figure and ornament to obey a common scale. Small people, bright signs and the pink heart-like form share a yellow field according to their pictorial importance rather than their physical size. The result can be read through its scattered incidents, without forcing them into the continuous space expected of a conventional scene.

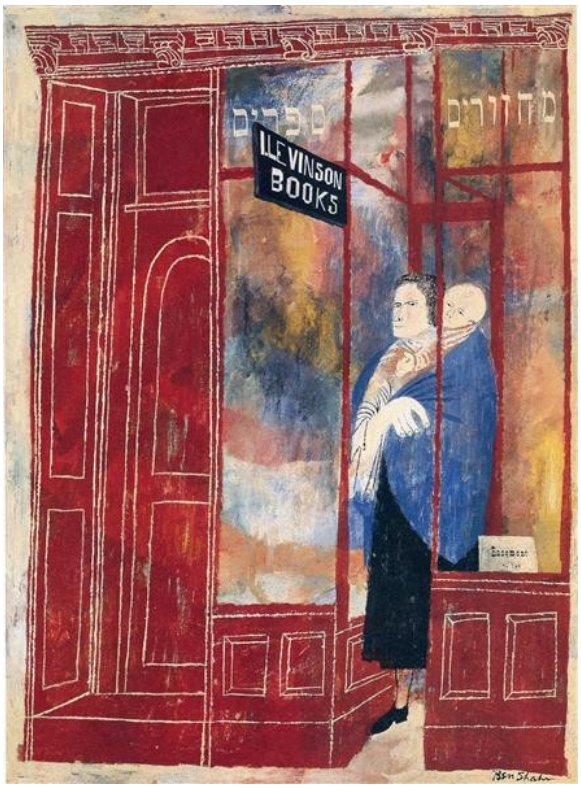
Object source · Open artwork

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Bookshop: Hebrew Books, Holy Day Books

Ben Shahn

1953 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Ben Shahn. Bookshop: Hebrew Books, Holy Day Books. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

The lettering tells us what kind of shop this is before the figure at its door can tell us anything about a particular day. Shahn lets words carry cultural information that a generic storefront would lose. Thin lines hold doorway, sign and person together. The red entrance gives that precise, modest business a place within the street.

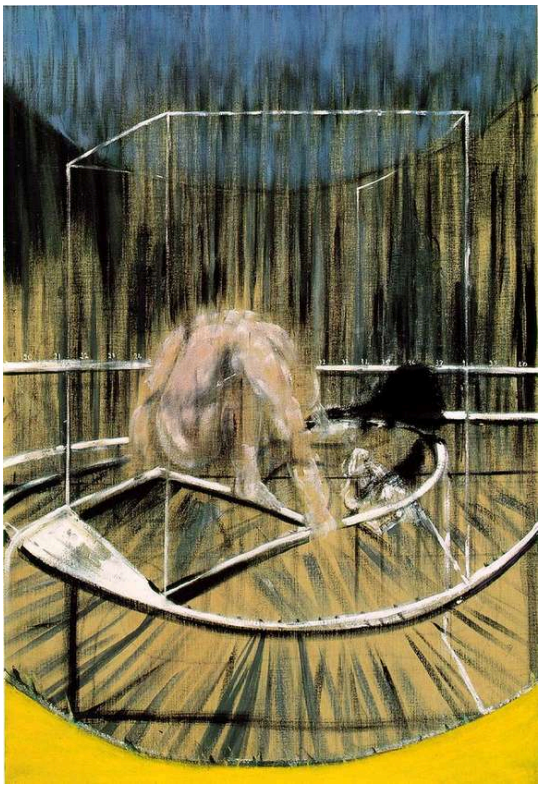
Object source · Open artwork

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Study for Crouching Nude

Francis Bacon

1952 · Oil on canvas · Detroit Institute of Arts



Francis Bacon. Study for Crouching Nude. WikiArt source label: Francis Bacon Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/francis-bacon/study-for-crouching-nude-1952 · Francis Bacon Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

Bacon surrounds the crouching body with a cage-like diagram, then refuses to give the anatomy an equally settled shape. The contrast matters: the enclosure offers clear boundaries against which the figure's instability becomes apparent. Vertical streaks disturb the darkness behind it. Confinement is carried by the body's position and by the measured structure that leaves it so little room.

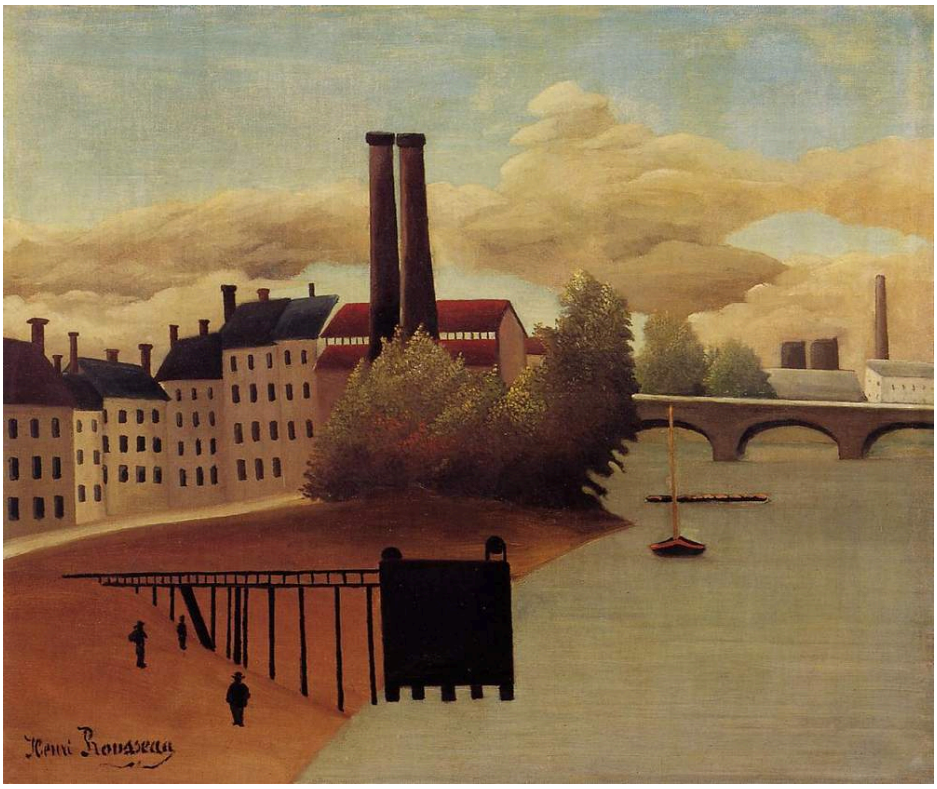
Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

View of the Outskirts of Paris

Henri Rousseau

1896 · Oil on canvas · Detroit Institute of Arts



Henri Rousseau. View of the Outskirts of Paris. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-rousseau/view-of-the-outskirts-of-paris-1896 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Rousseau's factories and chimneys stand as clear, separated shapes beyond the river. Industry enters the landscape without the crowded activity of Rivera's mural. The difference is one of viewpoint as much as subject: this observer remains outside, on a bank from which production appears as buildings rather than labour. The quiet arrangement does not tell us what happens inside them.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

The Appeal (Two Women and a Man)

Titian

Early–mid 16th century · Detroit Institute of Arts



Two women and a man (Trio). WikiArt; Giorgione. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Hands and glances link the three closely grouped figures, but their relationship does not yield an unambiguous story. The work has also received changing attributions and titles. The DIA now catalogues it as Titian's *The Appeal*, dated to the early–mid sixteenth century. An attentive reading can follow the exchange without pretending that either the scene or its authorship has always been settled.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

The Holy Family

Nicolas Poussin

1641 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Nicolas Poussin. The Holy Family. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Mary bends towards the child and cradle while Joseph occupies a more distant place. Poussin gives these unequal degrees of closeness a firm architectural setting. Drapery and the tall opening hold the room together without obscuring the small act of care at its centre. The sacred subject rests on a recognisable division between attending directly and remaining nearby.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

The Blind Leading the Blind

Louise Bourgeois

1949 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Louise Bourgeois. The Blind Leading the Blind. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Bourgeois connects the pink uprights with a shared horizontal bar, but their tapering lower ends make that collective structure look precarious. The title suggests a group of people without requiring heads or complete bodies. Support and dependence can be examined in the construction itself: each repeated element belongs to the whole, yet the whole offers no comfortably broad footing.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

The Elbe near Dresden

Oskar Kokoschka

1921 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Oskar Kokoschka. The Elbe Near Dresden. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The church tower and town retain their identities amid Kokoschka's strongly worked colour. Blue water and red and green bands give the banks an activity that continues into the sky. Rather than placing fixed buildings before a changing river, the painting subjects the whole view to an unsettled surface. Architecture participates in the movement instead of stopping it.

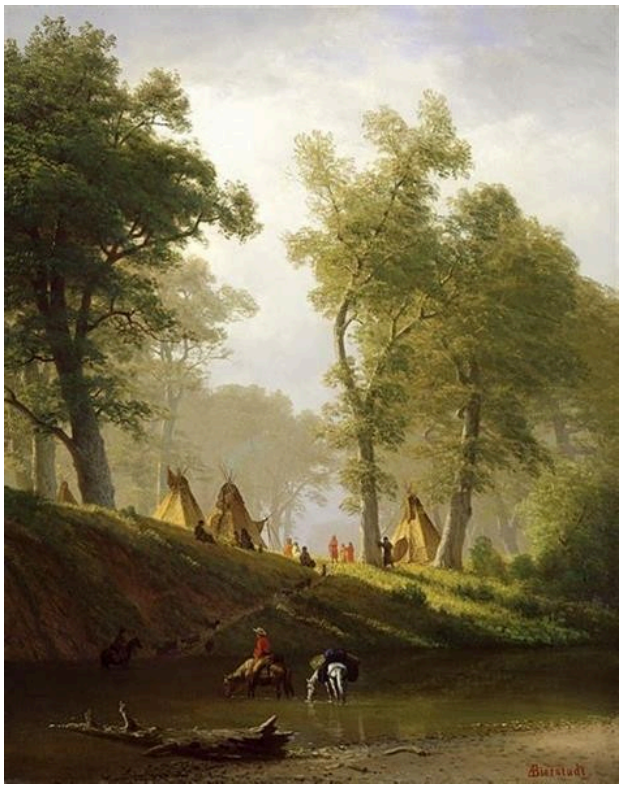
Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

The Wolf River, Kansas

Albert Bierstadt

1859 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Albert Bierstadt. The Wolf River, Kansas. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Tents and people occupy a clearing beneath tall trees. Bierstadt's distant vantage makes their activities part of a much larger distribution of light and shade. It is useful to notice the limits of that vantage: the painting shows an inhabited place, but its small figures do not provide a full account of the people who live there.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Girl with a Mandolin

Giovanni Battista Tiepolo

1758-1760 · Detroit Institute of Arts



Giovanni Battista Tiepolo. Girl with a Mandolin. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The instrument gives the woman's hands a shared task and carries a diagonal across her body. Her turning head prevents the pose from becoming an evenly presented display of costume. Tiepolo brings pale skin and bright fabric out of the dark setting, but the painting's animation depends on that slight mismatch between the direction of the face and the occupied hands.

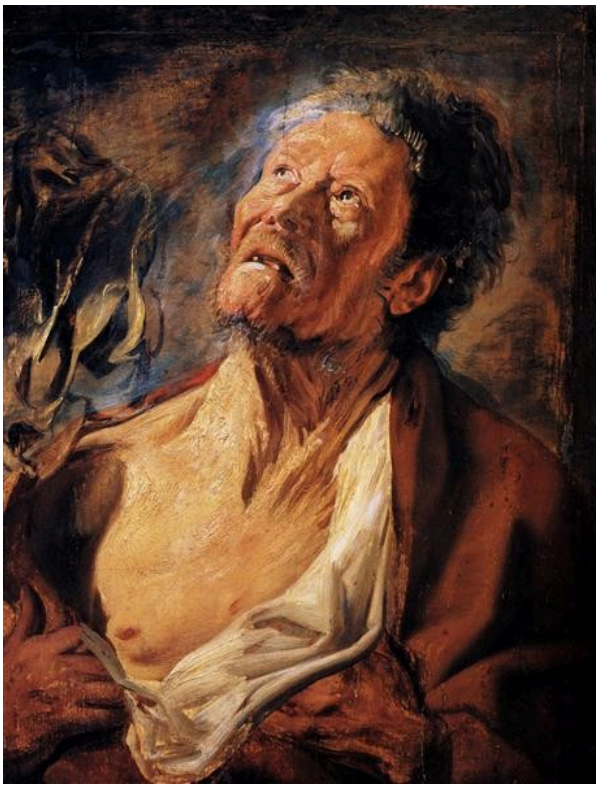
Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Job

Jacob Jordaens

c. 1620 · Oil on oak panel · Detroit Institute of Arts



Job. WikiArt; WikiArt. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; complete source frame. · Public domain

Jordaens makes the weathered face and exposed chest the substance of Job's appeal. The upward gaze carries the biblical subject without dissolving the man into an abstract emblem of patience. Light crosses flesh that appears vulnerable and particular. After the factories, landscapes and rooms in this selection, a body and a lifted pair of eyes are enough.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 43.418

Return to the scale of a body

Compare Rivera's workers with Bacon's enclosed figure, then with the reader in the small Van Eyck panel. The different settings give a body different freedoms. These are collection selections, not a guaranteed display route; check current museum records when planning a visit, especially for works with changing attributions or exhibition status.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s discussion of mass, line and tone offers a way into both small panels and large figure groups. Compare the tightly outlined bodies in Rivera with the nearly dissolved forms in Whistler.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12